

Trump reenters state’s water battle

His executive order aims to increase flow, but detractors say it would help only the agriculture industry.

By IAN JAMES

President Trump has signed an order directing federal agencies to “maximize” water deliveries in California and “override” state policies if necessary. Trump’s executive order outlines steps intended to increase the amount of water pumped from the Sacramento-San Joaquin River Delta.

The directive was praised by agencies that supply water to farmlands in the San Joaquin Valley, which could receive more water under the changes ordered by Trump.

Westlands Water District, the largest agricultural water supplier in the Central Valley, welcomed the executive order.

“It’s clear that what we’ve been doing for the past few decades has not been working; not for the people, for agriculture, or for the fish,” the district said in a written statement. Westlands General Manager Allison Febbo said the district intends to work with government agencies “to bring common sense back” to water management in the valley, one of the nation’s major food-producing regions.

Environmental groups said the measures Trump is seeking, if fully carried out, would be disastrous for populations of threatened and endangered fish, as well as the state’s commercial and recreational fisheries and the deteriorating ecosystem of the delta.

“It would mean the loss of California’s most important wild salmon runs, devastating impacts on salmon fishing jobs, enormous degradation in delta water quality,” said Barry Nelson, a policy representative for the fishing group Golden State Salmon Assn. He also flagged the issue of states’ rights: “This is a very clear [See Water, A6]



BRIAN VANDER BRUG Los Angeles Times

A CALTRANS crew arrives Monday to assess the damage to Topanga Canyon Boulevard, which was closed because of mud and debris.

Rain, snow end Southland dry spell



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

EDISON is under scrutiny for the Eaton fire, which destroyed 7,000 homes and killed 17 people this month. Above, an Altadena apartment building burns.

Edison accused of hiding data in federal complaint over 2017 fire

By NOAH GOLDBERG

When the Creek fire exploded in the Angeles National Forest in 2017, suspicions quickly fell on electric power lines as the cause.

Witnesses reported seeing a snapped line on a high-voltage transmission tower in Little Tujunga Canyon around the time the fire started, and investigators focused their attention there.

“There was fire concentrated over there and sparks coming off the pylon. ... It spread each direction,” one resident told The Times.

But it would take seven more years for federal au- [See Edison, A5]

Storm causes mudslides and flooding, but a weather expert says it was largely beneficial

By GRACE TOOHEY, RONG-GONG LIN II AND NOAH HAGGERTY

Southern California emerged from weeks of unprecedented fires, winds and smoke Monday to rain-covered streets, puddles on sidewalks and snow-capped mountains as the first storm of the season finally brought some relief from record-dry conditions.

By midmorning Monday, the heaviest rain and snowfall had mostly passed through the Southland, but cleanup and recovery efforts continued after bursts of intense downpours hit the mountains and foothills, including near some recent burn areas.

“There definitely were some issues,” said Ryan Kittell, a National Weather Service meteorologist in Oxnard, citing several road closures because of mudslides and flooding. “Fortunately, I think the heaviest rain in L.A. County happened over the ocean — but it was pretty close.”

Although the much-anticipated rainfall had many fire-weary Angelenos hopeful, forecasters had also been worried that the system would create thunderstorms or strong storm cells that would inundate the fresh burn scars, wreaking more havoc on the disaster-fatigued region. But luckily, Kittell said, the heaviest rain missed those areas.

“This was a largely beneficial rain. ... I think we dodged a bullet,” he said. “It helped with the firefighting and definitely gives us a break from fire weather.”

However, the amount of rainfall isn’t quite enough to keep Los Angeles’ fire season from dragging into February.

It would take 2 to 4 inches of rain to comfortably consider the wildfire season over, Kittell said. This storm dropped, generally, half an inch to 1.5 inches across the L.A. Basin.

“It’s not quite where we’d be comfortable to say we’d be good for the season, but certainly providing relief for [See Storm, A5]

Immigration surge skewed 2024 homeless numbers

True picture of the problem in the U.S. and progress in L.A. is hidden

By DOUG SMITH



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

JAIDELIN CHACON speaks to her daughter Celeste, 5, on Skid Row in Los Angeles last year.

A surge in immigration that peaked just as last year’s homeless count was taken accounted for the bulk of its historic rise reported in December, grossly inflating the picture of homelessness in America.

Because the local agencies taking the count across the country do not ask for immigration status, homeless numbers ballooned in a handful of states that took in tens of thousands of immigrants, and those states, in turn, pushed the national number to an unprecedented high of nearly 772,000.

In releasing the Annual Homelessness Assessment Report in the last few days of 2024, the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development cited immigration, along with the shortage of affordable housing and na- [See Homelessness, A9]

Gazans journey back to north

Israel warns the tens of thousands of returnees against aiding militants amid a cease-fire. **WORLD, A3**

The rich turn to private hydrants

Companies are reporting skyrocketing sales since the Jan. 7 wildfires in Los Angeles County. **BUSINESS, A8**

Investigating a famed war photo

Documentary “The Stringer” calls into question the origins of “Napalm Girl” photo. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Some sun and cool.
L.A. Basin: 61/46. **B6**

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‘Free speech’ decree comes with muzzle

Trump ordered an end to censorship. But he has gone after media, federal officials and others, observers say.

By KEVIN RECTOR

In one of his first acts in office, President Trump issued an executive order promising to end government censorship and restore free speech.

The order accused the outgoing Biden administration of harassing social media companies and violating the rights of ordinary Americans “under the guise” of combating disinformation online, and said federal resources would no longer be used to “unconstitutionally

abridge the free speech of any American citizen.”

The order echoed a recurring theme from Trump’s campaign — that liberals across the federal government are censoring conservative voices to advance their own “woke” agenda — and immediately resonated with his followers.

“This order is a critical step to ensure the government cannot dictate what speech is permissible or weaponize private entities to enforce censorship,” said Mark Trammell of the Center for American Liberty, a conservative rights group founded by California attorney Harmeet K. Dhillon, Trump’s nominee to lead the Justice Department’s Civil Rights Division.

However, many others said they found Trump’s or- [See ‘Free speech,’ A7]



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